

# Christ Died While We Were Sinners

*Commentary Notes • Romans 5:6–8*

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Romans 5:6–8 places Christ’s death against human weakness and sin. Paul’s repeated time markers and his comparison with rare human sacrifice give the reader a precise account of divine initiative. This note follows those three verses; the related Digital Study develops reconciliation across Paul’s letters.

## **The argument surrounding these verses**

Romans 5 opens with justified believers having peace with God through Jesus Christ (vv. 1–2). Paul then speaks of suffering, endurance, hope, and the love of God poured into believers’ hearts through the Holy Spirit (vv. 3–5). Verses 6–8 do not interrupt that argument. They give an objective ground for confidence in God’s love: Christ’s death for people who had no strength to secure the standing Paul has described.

The next verses carry Paul’s reasoning forward to justification by Christ’s blood, salvation from wrath, reconciliation while enemies, and rejoicing in God (vv. 9–11). The present passage is one movement in that larger argument. It should not be asked to supply every distinction the following verses make.

## **The first time marker Romans 5:6**

Paul says that while “we” were still without strength, Christ died for the ungodly at the appointed time. The condition and the action occur on opposite sides of the sentence: human inability does not initiate a remedy; Christ acts for people described as ungodly. “Without strength” should not be reduced to ordinary fatigue or a passing loss of motivation. In this argument it belongs to the former condition from which God’s action delivers.

Paul’s timing language identifies Christ’s act within God’s purpose. The verse does not tell the reader to calculate a date, nor does it claim that the people in view first reached a sufficient level of regret. Its force lies in the order: the death occurs while they lack strength.

### **A rare human comparison Romans 5:7**

Paul briefly considers how unusual it is for a person to die for a righteous person, though someone might perhaps dare to die for a good person. The terms “righteous” and “good” need not be made into a complete ranking of moral character here. Their rhetorical job is to make a point about the rarity of voluntary death even for a person judged worthy of help.

The comparison should be allowed to do its limited work. Paul does not say that no human being ever sacrifices life for another. He grants a possibility, then places God’s action beside that possibility in verse 8. The human case makes the timing and recipients of Christ’s death more striking.

### **The second time marker Romans 5:8**

God demonstrates his own love in that Christ died for us while we were still sinners. The phrase “while we were still sinners” corresponds to “while we were still without strength” in verse 6. Paul has not inserted a period of reform between the two descriptions. He points to Christ’s death amid the condition that made divine help necessary.

The verse speaks of God’s demonstrated love through a particular event. It does not ask believers to infer God’s attitude solely from the ease of their current circumstances. The preceding paragraph already includes suffering, and the following argument promises salvation in relation to Christ’s death and life. God’s love is displayed in what Christ did, not measured by the absence of hardship.

### **What the passage establishes and leaves open**

Romans 5:6–8 establishes that Christ died for the ungodly and sinners while they lacked strength. Paul’s comparison with rare human sacrifice highlights God’s initiative. These verses do not, by themselves, define every benefit that follows from Christ’s death or say that every person has already received reconciliation.

Read Romans 5:1–11 in one sitting. Mark each description of the former condition, each time marker, and the verbs that describe what God has done and what believers have received. Digital Study 55, Reconciled to God, brings this passage together with 2 Corinthians 5, Ephesians 2, and Colossians 1 to explain enmity, peace, the apostolic appeal, and the ministry of reconciliation.